

The Stakeholder Update

How to share your progress and build a community of supporters

Whether you're talking to a high-level investor or a small group of loyal followers, people want to feel like they are part of a journey. A good update isn't just a list of things you did — it's a story of where you're going. By sharing your wins and your challenges consistently, you turn "customers" into "stakeholders" who are invested in your success. This guide breaks that process down into three simple, repeatable sections.

THE INKWELL REPOSITORY

STRATEGIC COMMUNICATIONS

Why Updates Matter

Most people think of updates as administrative tasks — something to check off a list before moving on to the "real work." But that perspective misses the point entirely. Every update you send is an act of relationship-building. It's a signal to the people around you that you're moving forward, that you're thoughtful about your work, and that you value their presence in your orbit. Whether your audience is a single client or a thousand subscribers, the principle is the same: people root for those they feel connected to.

Consider the difference between two businesses. The first sends a polished quarterly report full of metrics and milestones. The second sends a brief, honest note every month that includes a win, a challenge, and a question for the reader. The first feels like a corporation. The second feels like a partner. Over time, the second business will consistently outperform the first in loyalty, referrals, and long-term trust — not because their product is better, but because their communication creates a sense of shared investment.

Without a Strategy

- Updates feel random and inconsistent
- Audience forgets you exist between touchpoints
- Wins go uncelebrated and unnoticed
- Challenges feel like surprises or failures
- Supporters become passive observers

With a Strategy

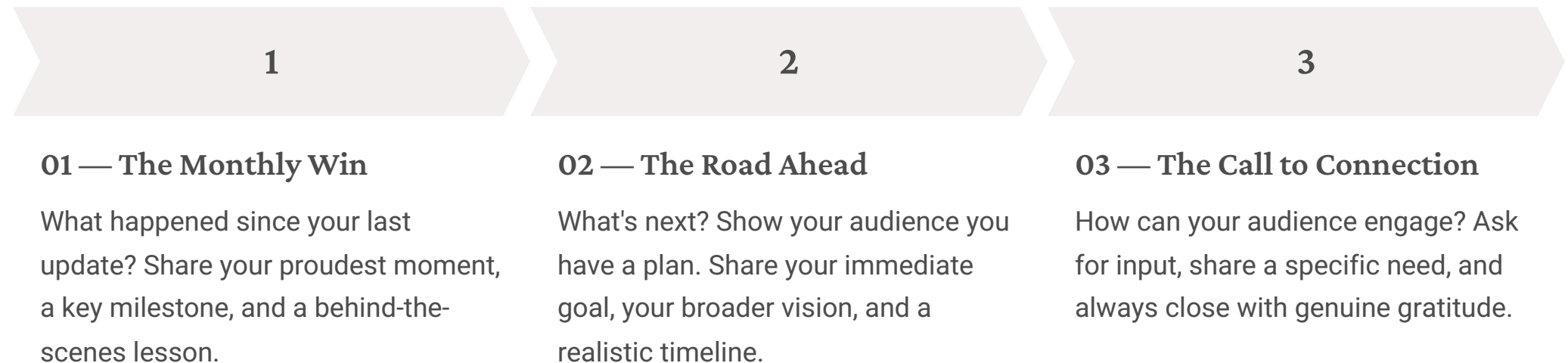
- Every update reinforces your vision and momentum
- Audience feels like insiders, not outsiders
- Wins are shared and celebrated together
- Challenges become stories of resilience
- Supporters become active stakeholders

The key insight is this: your stakeholders don't need you to be perfect. They need you to be present. A consistent, honest update — even one that acknowledges a setback — builds more trust than a glossy, infrequent announcement. People want to follow a real journey, not a highlight reel.

The 3-Part Structure at a Glance

Every great stakeholder update follows the same basic architecture. Think of it as a narrative arc: you start with what happened, you point toward what's coming, and you invite your reader to participate. This three-part structure works whether you're writing a formal investor email, a casual social media post, or a client-facing newsletter. It's flexible enough to adapt to any tone or medium, but structured enough to ensure you never leave your audience wondering what the point was.

The beauty of this framework is its simplicity. You don't need a communications degree or a dedicated PR team. You need three honest answers: What happened? What's next? How can we connect? When you can answer those three questions clearly and briefly, you have everything you need to write an update that resonates. The sections that follow break each one down with specific prompts and examples.



Notice that each section serves a different emotional purpose. The Monthly Win creates pride and momentum. The Road Ahead creates confidence and anticipation. The Call to Connection creates intimacy and reciprocity. Together, they form a complete communication that doesn't just inform — it engages. When you use this structure consistently, your audience will begin to expect and look forward to your updates, which is exactly the relationship you want to build.

Part 1: The Monthly Win

What Happened

The first section of your update is your anchor. It grounds your reader in the reality of what you've accomplished since the last time you connected. But here's the critical filter: don't overwhelm people with every tiny detail. Your update is not a project management report. It's a curated story. Pick the **three most important things** that happened since your last update and lead with those. Everything else can wait for a different conversation.

Why three? Because three is memorable. One thing feels thin. Five things feels like a list. Three things creates a rhythm — a beginning, a middle, and an end within the section itself. Each of the three elements below serves a distinct purpose in building that narrative arc. Together, they give your reader a complete picture of your progress without demanding their full attention.

The Big Win

What is the one thing you're most proud of this month? This doesn't have to be a massive, headline-worthy achievement. It can be a client testimonial that made your day, a process you finally streamlined, or a creative breakthrough you've been chasing for weeks. The Big Win is your energy signal — it tells your audience that momentum is real and that good things are happening. Lead with this. It sets the tone for everything that follows.

The Milestone

Did you finish a project? Launch a new page? Hit a specific goal? Milestones are the markers of progress that your audience can actually see and measure. They're proof that the work is moving forward in a tangible way. A milestone could be as significant as a product launch or as simple as publishing your tenth blog post. What matters is that it represents forward motion — something that didn't exist last month that exists now.

The Behind-the-Scenes

Share one small "aha!" moment or a lesson you learned. This is the element that most people skip, and it's the one that matters most for building genuine connection. When you share something you figured out — a tool that changed your workflow, a mistake that taught you something valuable, a realization about your audience — you make your brand feel human and relatable. People don't follow perfection. They follow authenticity.

Part 2: The Road Ahead

What's Next

An update that only looks backward is a eulogy, not a conversation. The second section of your stakeholder update is where you demonstrate that you're not just reacting to the world — you're shaping it. Looking forward shows your audience that you are in control, that you have a plan, and that there are exciting things on the horizon worth paying attention to. This section creates anticipation, and anticipation is what keeps people coming back.

The Road Ahead doesn't require you to reveal everything. In fact, it's often more powerful to give your audience a glimpse rather than a full blueprint. You want them to feel like insiders who know something is coming, not like analysts who can predict your every move. The goal is to create enough clarity to build confidence and enough mystery to maintain interest. Think of it as a trailer, not a spoiler.

The Immediate Goal

What are you working on right now? Be specific. "Working on new things" is vague and forgettable. "Finalizing the design system for our Q2 launch" is concrete and compelling. Your immediate goal tells your audience where your energy is focused and gives them something to watch for in the next update. It also holds you accountable — when you tell people what you're working on, you're more likely to follow through.

The Vision

How does this month's work fit into the Big Picture? This is your chance to remind your audience why any of this matters. Connect the tactical to the strategic. If you're launching a new service, explain how it fits into your broader mission. If you're hiring, explain what it means for the quality of work you deliver. The Vision paragraph is where you inspire — it's the reminder that there's a larger story unfolding, and your audience is part of it.

The Timeline

Give a realistic idea of when the next big announcement or release is coming. Timelines create anticipation and demonstrate that you respect your audience's attention. You don't need to commit to exact dates — "sometime in June" or "before the end of Q3" is perfectly acceptable. What matters is that you're giving your audience something to look forward to, and that you're being honest about the pace of your work.

Part 3: The Call to Connection

The Ask

Every update is an opportunity — and if you don't use it, you're leaving value on the table. The Call to Connection is the section that transforms a one-way broadcast into a two-way conversation. It's where you invite your audience to participate, to contribute, and to feel like they have a role in your story. People don't just want to watch your journey. They want to be part of it. This section gives them that invitation.

The word "ask" can feel intimidating, especially if you're not used to putting yourself out there. But the most effective calls to connection aren't demands — they're invitations. You're not asking your audience to do you a favor. You're giving them the opportunity to contribute to something they care about. When framed that way, most people are genuinely excited to help. The three approaches below cover the most common and effective types of engagement.



Ask for Input

"I'm choosing between two designs — which do you prefer?" This type of question is low-effort for your audience but high-engagement for your brand. It makes people feel like their opinion matters, and it often generates surprisingly useful feedback. You can ask about product features, content topics, visual directions, or even the name of something you're working on. The key is to make the choice clear and the stakes feel real.



The Specific Need

If you're looking for a specific resource, a new tool, or just a recommendation, ask for it directly. People love to be helpful — it's one of the most reliable truths in human psychology. When you tell your audience that you're searching for a new project management tool or need an introduction to someone in a specific industry, you're not showing weakness. You're showing trust. And trust, reciprocated, is the foundation of every strong professional relationship.



The Thank You

Always acknowledge the people who helped you get through the month. Gratitude is the best way to keep supporters in your corner, and it costs nothing. Name names when you can — "Huge thanks to Sarah for the introduction" or "Grateful to our community for the incredible response." Specific gratitude feels genuine. Generic gratitude feels like a formality. Take the extra thirty seconds to make it real.

The Format Rules

Structure is only half the battle. The way your update looks and reads is just as important as what it says. A brilliant message buried in a wall of text will never get the attention it deserves. These three format rules are non-negotiable — not because they're arbitrary design preferences, but because they reflect how real people actually consume information. Your audience is busy, distracted, and scanning. Write for that reality.

1

Keep It Brief

If it takes more than two minutes to read, it's too long. This isn't a hard limit on word count — it's a hard limit on respect for your audience's time. Use bullet points liberally. Use bold text to highlight key ideas. Break up long paragraphs into shorter ones. A stakeholder update should feel like a conversation, not a report. If you find yourself writing more than a page, ask yourself: what can I cut? What can I save for next time? Brevity is a discipline, and it's one of the most valuable skills in professional communication.

2

Be Honest

Don't be afraid to mention a challenge you faced. Overcoming a hurdle is more inspiring than pretending everything is perfect. Your audience doesn't need you to be flawless — they need you to be real. When you share a struggle and how you worked through it, you're not undermining your credibility. You're building it. Vulnerability, when paired with competence, is one of the most powerful combinations in leadership communication. The key is to always pair the challenge with the lesson or the resolution.

3

Consistency Is Key

Whether it's once a month or once a quarter, pick a schedule and stick to it. Reliability is the foundation of professional trust. Your audience will begin to anticipate your updates, and that anticipation is a form of loyalty. If you commit to monthly updates and then disappear for three months, you've done more harm than good. It's better to under-promise and over-deliver than the reverse. Set a cadence you can actually maintain, and treat it like a commitment, not a suggestion.

📌 **Pro Tip:** Write your updates on the same day each month — the last Friday, the first Monday, whatever works for your rhythm. When communication becomes a habit, it stops feeling like a task and starts feeling like part of who you are.

Choosing Your Format

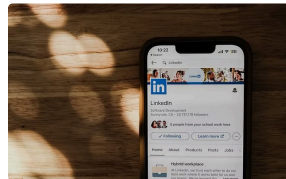
One of the most common questions people have about stakeholder updates is: where should I send this? The answer is more flexible than you might think. The three-part structure outlined in this guide is platform-agnostic — it works in a formal email newsletter, a LinkedIn post, a Slack update to your team, or even a recorded video message. The medium should match your audience and your relationship with them, not the other way around.

The key is to maintain the structure regardless of the format. A social media post might compress each section into a single sentence. A client email might expand each one into a short paragraph. A quarterly investor update might include data and visuals alongside each section. The framework adapts; the principles don't. Here's a quick reference for matching your format to your audience.



Email Newsletter

Best for: Clients, partners, and a dedicated subscriber list. Email gives you the most space to develop each section fully and allows for richer formatting. It's the most traditional and most expected format for professional updates.



Social Media Post

Best for: A broader audience, brand building, and public visibility. Compress each section into one or two sentences. Use the three-part structure as a caption framework. Great for reaching new stakeholders who don't yet know your work.



Internal Team Update

Best for: Colleagues, collaborators, and internal stakeholders. This format can be more candid and detailed. Use it to align your team around shared goals and celebrate collective wins. The honesty rule matters even more internally.

The Inkwell Philosophy

"A brand is more than just a logo — it's a relationship. When you communicate with transparency and intent, you aren't just sending an update; you are building a legacy."

This philosophy is the foundation of everything The Inkwell Repository stands for. It's the belief that the way you show up in your communications — consistently, honestly, and with clear intention — is what separates a business from a brand, and a brand from a legacy. A logo can be copied. A product can be replicated. But the relationship you build with your stakeholders through thoughtful, regular communication? That's uniquely yours, and it compounds over time.

Think of every update you send as a brick in a larger structure. Individually, each one might feel small — a brief note about a win, a challenge, and a question. But over months and years, those bricks become a wall. That wall is your reputation. It's the thing people point to when they recommend you to someone else. It's the reason a potential client chooses you over a competitor with a similar offering. Communication isn't a tactic. It's a strategy.

Why This Fits Your Journey

The Stakeholder Update is designed as a natural next step after establishing your core brand identity and client experience. Once you know who you are and how you serve your clients, the next move is to let the right people know you're moving. This guide works whether you're writing a corporate newsletter or a simple status update on social media. It breaks the intimidating task of "PR" down into three easy-to-follow sections that anyone can execute, regardless of budget or team size.

Universal. Simple. Repeatable. That's the Inkwell standard for every framework we create.

The Core Belief

Transparency builds trust. Trust builds loyalty.
Loyalty builds legacy. Every update you send is a chance to move that chain forward — or to let it stall.
Choose to move it forward.

Your Action Plan

Knowledge without action is just information. The best way to internalize this framework is to use it — this week, not someday. Below is a simple, practical action plan that will take you from reading this guide to sending your first structured stakeholder update. Each step is designed to be completed in under thirty minutes, and together they'll give you everything you need to start building that legacy we talked about.

01

Pick Your Cadence

Decide right now: will you send updates monthly, bi-monthly, or quarterly? Write the date of your first update on your calendar. Treat it like a client meeting — non-negotiable and protected. Consistency starts with a commitment, and a commitment starts with a date on the calendar.

03

Draft Your First Update

Use the three-part structure: one Monthly Win (Big Win, Milestone, Behind-the-Scenes), one Road Ahead (Immediate Goal, Vision, Timeline), and one Call to Connection (Input, Need, or Thank You). Write it in under thirty minutes. Don't overthink it — your first update doesn't need to be perfect. It just needs to exist.

02

Choose Your Platform

Where does your audience actually pay attention? If your stakeholders live in their email inbox, write a newsletter. If they're on LinkedIn, write a post. If your key relationships are in a group chat, write a message. Meet your audience where they are — don't make them come looking for you.

04

Send It and Learn

Hit send. Then pay attention to what happens. Who responds? What do they say? What questions do they ask? Every response is data. Every silence is data too. Use what you learn to make your next update even better. The framework stays the same; your voice gets stronger with every iteration.

👉 **Your First Update Checklist:** Three wins identified ✓ Forward-looking goals written ✓ One genuine ask included ✓ Gratitude expressed ✓ Under two minutes to read ✓ Sent on schedule ✓

The Stakeholder Update is more than a communication tactic — it's a mindset. It's the decision to show up consistently, to be honest about both the wins and the challenges, and to treat every person in your orbit as a partner in your journey. That mindset, practiced over time, is what transforms a business into a brand and a brand into a legacy. Start this week. Your stakeholders are waiting.